

Executive Summary of the REPORT OF THE PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION REFORM COMMISSION

On October 3, 2024, the Government of the People's Republic of Bangladesh issued a notification through the Cabinet Division, forming the "Public Administration Reform Commission" under the leadership of Abdul Mueyed Chowdhury. The objective of the commission was to establish a citizen-centric, accountable, efficient, and impartial public administration system. Subsequently, on October 24, 2024, another notification was issued to expand the commission's membership. The commission was instructed to commence its activities from October 3, 2024, incorporating relevant opinions and submitting its report to the Honorable Chief Adviser of the Interim Government within 90 days. The deadline was later extended twice, ultimately setting January 31, 2025, as the final submission date.

Methodology And Data Collection

To formulate its report, the commission followed multiple approaches for data collection, analysis, and recommendations. These included identifying key areas of public administration reform, reviewing past reform efforts in Bangladesh, analyzing recent public administration initiatives in South and Southeast Asian countries, and distributing questionnaires to gather opinions from government officials, private sector representatives, civil society members, NGO personnel, and citizens at district and sub-district levels. Additionally, stakeholder discussions, interviews, case studies, and data analysis were conducted. The commission received valuable insights and recommendations from thousands of citizens, significantly contributing to the report's preparation. The chairman and members of the commission visited eight districts and five sub-districts, engaging with grassroots citizens and field-level government officials.

Stakeholder Consultations

The commission engaged with representatives of various civil service cadres, requesting their expectations and suggestions, which were provided both orally and in written form. Separate discussions were held to address healthcare sector concerns. Moreover, consultations took place with leaders of the Federation of Bangladesh Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FBCCI) regarding administrative reforms. Journalists regularly covering news at the Secretariat were also consulted. To gather political perspectives, letters were sent to the presidents and general secretaries of 13 political parties, seeking their written recommendations. In response, the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP), Jamaat-e-Islami, Amar Bangladesh Party, and National People's Party submitted their recommendations.

Reform Objectives

As per the Cabinet Division's notification on October 3, 2024, the commission was tasked with preparing a report addressing public administration reforms to make it: a) Citizen-centric, b) Accountable, c) Efficient, d) Impartial.

A detailed review of these objectives indicated the need for further enhancements. In addition to making public administration citizen-centric, accountable, efficient, and impartial, it should also be effective and result-oriented. Achieving competent administration requires training, capacity-building, and the development of strategic leadership. Considering these factors, the commission expanded the objectives to include the following six key goals:

- a) Citizen-centric public administration
- b) Transparent and accountable administration
- c) Enhancement of administrative efficiency and capacity
- d) Impartial public administration
- e) Competent and result-oriented public service
- f) Effective public administration

Report Structure And Recommendations

Since its inception, the commission has held as many as 49 meetings to draft its report and recommendations. The final report is divided into 17 chapters, comprising over 200 recommendations across 14 thematic areas. To facilitate implementation, the recommendations are categorized into short-term (6 months), medium-term (1 year), and long-term strategies.

The key chapters of the report include:

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

In the introductory chapter background of the Public Administration Reform Commission, scope of work, report preparation methodology, stakeholder engagement, and report structure were discussed.

CHAPTER 2: JUSTIFICATION FOR PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION REFORM IN BANGLADESH

The second chapter reviews the past reform efforts, recent experiences in South and Southeast Asian countries, public opinion on new reform initiatives, key challenges, and reform objectives.

CHAPTER 3: VISION, PRINCIPLES, GOALS, AND LEADERSHIP IN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

In the third chapter, a framework outlining the vision, core principles, goals of public administration and leadership structure for public administration reform, the necessity of a permanent reform commission, and the introduction of digital methodologies for reform implementation were discussed. This structured approach ensures that public administration reforms in Bangladesh are comprehensive, inclusive, and effectively implemented. The following recommendations are made in this chapter:

3.1 Vision for Public Administration: "Establishing good governance at all levels of the Republic to ensure citizen-centric service delivery."

3.2 Core Principles of Public Administration: A people-friendly, ethical, impartial, transparent, accountable, efficient, and effective public administration.

3.3 Goals of Public Administration: "Ensuring the legal rights of the citizens of the Republic and providing them with the designated services."

3.4 Implementation Timeline for Recommendations: Recommendations are categorized into short-term (6 months), medium-term (1–2 years), and long-term phases.

3.5 Formation of a Permanent Public Administration Reform Commission: Since public administration reform is a continuous process, the establishment of an independent and permanent Public Administration Reform Commission is recommended to ensure sustainable reform implementation.

3.6 Role of the Cabinet Division and Public Administration Reform Commission: The Cabinet Division will develop a roadmap for implementing the public administration reform program, in alignment with the Constitution and relevant international regulations followed by Bangladesh.

3.7 Development of a Generic Roadmap: The Cabinet Division will formulate a generic roadmap for public administration reforms. Ministries and Departments will then prepare their respective reform roadmaps based on this framework. These roadmaps will be submitted to the Permanent Public Administration Reform Commission through the Cabinet Division. The commission will review and finalize recommendations for government consideration. Ministries and Departments will issue necessary directives to district and sub-district offices for effective implementation.

3.8 Establishment of an Innovation Lab: To conduct research on innovative processes and policies in public administration, a specialized institution (such as BPATC, BIGM, or an equivalent organization) will be designated as an innovation lab.

3.9 Web Portal-Based Digital Platform: To make the performance management of all state institutions more citizen-centric and effective, procedural and regulatory aspects will be integrated into a web portal-based digital system. This portal will facilitate key performance tracking, monitoring, evaluation, and feedback mechanisms.

3.10 Development of Digital Infrastructure: A digital infrastructure framework will be established from the Cabinet Division to district and sub-district levels, featuring:

- a) Centralized Data Management and Performance Monitoring System
- b) Digital Platforms for Administrative Processes and Service Delivery
- c) Integrated E-Governance System for Central and Local Government Operations
- d) Cloud-Based Digital Services, Unified Communication, and Data Interoperability

CHAPTER FOUR: REFORMS FOR BEHAVIORAL CHANGE IN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

This chapter discusses the necessity of reforms focused on behavioral change in public administration, highlighting the importance of incorporating fundamental values into the Civil Service Code. The discussion includes:

- a) The need for a value-driven Civil Service Code
- b) The significance of fundamental values in Bangladesh's public administration
- c) Experiences from other countries regarding civil service values and ethics
- d) The connection between the Code of Conduct for government officials and core public service values in Bangladesh
- e) A brief analysis of additional values relevant to government officials in the context of Bangladesh

These recommendations aim to transform the mindset and culture within public administration, ensuring a more ethical, responsible, and citizen-centric service delivery system. This section outlines recommendations for establishing ethical guidelines and behavioral reforms within public administration to ensure accountability, integrity, and professionalism. The following recommendations are made with the aims to establish a professional, ethical, and transparent public administration system:

- 4.1 Revised Code of Conduct:** Introduce an updated "Public Servants' Code of Conduct" with clear ethical and behavioral guidelines.
- 4.2 Oath of Allegiance:** Require newly appointed officials to sign an oath of allegiance, affirming loyalty, patriotism, integrity, duty, and accountability.
- 4.3 Ethics in Training Programs:** Include etiquette, ethical behavior, and professionalism in government training programs.
- 4.4 Culture of Consultation:** Promote a culture of seeking advice and feedback for better decision-making among public servants.
- 4.5 Ethics in Performance Evaluation:** Integrate moral values, discipline, and professional conduct into employee performance assessments.
- 4.6 Accountability & Transparency:** Establish specific guidelines to enhance accountability and transparency in governance.
- 4.7 Public Awareness Campaigns:** Conduct campaigns to educate citizens on government accountability and transparency.

CHAPTER FIVE: PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION FOR CITIZEN SERVICE IMPROVEMENT

The following recommendations are made with the objective of ensuring citizens' rights, enhancing citizen involvement in the decision-making process, securing citizens' right to information, and simplifying citizen services:

5.1 Digital Transformation and E-Service: To enhance the efficiency of public service systems, the government should adopt several initiatives, with a key strategy being the digital transformation of government services. The government may strengthen multiple e-government services, such as online tax filing, digital land records, and electronic birth registration, NID, and passport services. E-services can improve efficiency by reducing time and costs for public service delivery and increase accessibility for citizens in remote or underdeveloped areas. Furthermore, e-services can promote transparency and build trust between the government and citizens, while also being cost-effective and improving information management. To improve e-services, strengthening the National E-Service System (NSS) and mobile applications could streamline bureaucratic processes.

5.2 Right to Information Act: To ensure that citizens can easily and freely access government service-related information, the Right to Information Act (2009) and the Official Secrets Act of 1923 should be reviewed and amended. This is aimed at improving citizens' access to information and services, with further recommendations in subsequent chapters.

5.3 One-Stop Service and FBCCI: Despite the longstanding discussion of a "One-Stop Service" for services like trade licenses, electricity connections, water lines, and environmental clearances, it has yet to be implemented effectively. Therefore, it is recommended that outsourcing the responsibility for processing "One-Stop Service" applications to district chambers affiliated with the FBCCI could streamline this process. Subsequently, relevant authorities should expedite the issuance of licenses based on existing policies and laws.

5.4 Passports as a Fundamental Right: Issuing passports to citizens should be a fundamental state responsibility. It is recommended that the police verification process for issuing passports be abolished. If there are objections regarding any citizen, verification can be conducted at the airport. Additionally, the list of criminal case defendants could be made available online for easier access.

5.5 Public Hearings: According to the Right to Information Act, it should be mandated that all government departments provide citizens with information and address their complaints through public hearings.

5.6 Formation of Citizen Committees: Just as there are parliamentary standing committees to oversee the activities of ministries, it is recommended that "District Citizen Committee" and "Upazila Citizen Committee" be formed at the district and sub-district levels, comprising citizens from various professions. These committees should include student representatives as well. The committees will meet every four months, discuss government services, and send their minutes to the District Commissioner's website and to the relevant departmental heads.

5.7 Involvement of Local NGOs and Social Organizations: It is recommended that local NGOs and social organizations be involved in public services, and initiatives should be taken to enhance their capacity.

5.8 Delegation of Authority to Local Bodies: In almost every government service delivery case, it is recommended that approval from the Ministry or Department head should not be a condition for implementation. Instead, powers and responsibilities related to finances, administration, and operations may be delegated to the local government authorities such as divisions, districts, Upazilas, and local government institutions. This would enable service delivery at the local level without needing approval from higher authorities.

5.9 Establishment of Hotline Numbers in Service Departments: Service-providing departments or organizations should establish hotlines to receive complaints about delays or harassment in receiving services. These hotlines should be open 24/7 or during office hours. The relevant departments should maintain records of complaints and inform complainants about the actions taken regarding their grievances.

5.10 Monitoring and Evaluation: The absence of effective monitoring and evaluation systems prevents the identification of inefficiencies and limitations in public services. Therefore, to enhance the effectiveness of public service delivery, it is crucial to strengthen monitoring and evaluation systems.

5.11 Accessibility of Internet: Digital divide reduces the effectiveness of e-governance initiatives and creates barriers in public service delivery. The state must ensure that all citizens have access to affordable and reliable internet services.

5.12 Eradicating Corruption: Corruption in public service delivery, such as bribery, favoritism, and nepotism, hinders the process. Thus, it is essential to take comprehensive measures to eliminate corruption in the public service sector.

5.13 Politicization of Public Service: To ensure efficient and impartial public service delivery, it is necessary to avoid political bias and party affiliation in the decision-making processes related to public services.

CHAPTER SIX: INSTITUTIONAL AND STRUCTURAL REFORM FOR CITIZEN-CENTERED ADMINISTRATION

The chapter includes the proposal to reorganize the number of ministries, grouping them into clusters for better coordination and efficiency. The chapter also highlights the need to reorganize the staffing structures of various ministries and departments. Additionally, it recommends restructuring sector corporations to optimize performance. Strengthening policy and planning cells in ministries and enhancing implementation, monitoring, and evaluation mechanisms are also emphasized. The separation of audit and accounting departments, as well as the differentiation between policy and implementation functions within the Revenue Board, are suggested to improve accountability. Administrative decentralization is proposed to empower local authorities, along with the creation of new administrative divisions. Further, consolidating land offices and sub-registry offices under one authority is recommended to streamline operations, while decentralizing marriage registration processes is suggested for greater accessibility and efficiency. These proposed reforms aim to create a more citizen-centered administration. The following recommendations are made in this chapter:

6.1 Reduction of Ministries: Currently, there are 43 ministries and 61 departments. The commission recommends reducing the ministries and reorganizing them into a total of 25 ministries and 40 departments.

6.2 Grouping Ministries into Five Categories: The commission recommends grouping all ministries into five categories based on their nature. The ministries/departments can be arranged into the following five categories:

(1) Regulatory Administration; (2) Finance, Industry, and Commerce; (3) Physical Infrastructure and Communications; (4) Agriculture and Environment; (5) Human Resources and Social Development

6.3 Reforming the Organizational and Staff Structures of Ministries/Departments, Directorates, and Field Offices: Each ministry/department should review its organizational and staffing structure in consultation with the relevant stakeholders. The proposals should be submitted to the Permanent Public Administration Reform Commission, which will review them and submit to the Prime Minister/Head of the government through the Cabinet Division for final approval.

6.4 Strengthening Policy and Planning Units in Ministries: Each ministry/department currently has a planning wing. To enhance the effectiveness of policy and planning work, each ministry/department should establish a policy and planning branch/wing, staffed with skilled and expert personnel.

6.5 Making Ministry Websites Dynamic: To ensure transparency in the implementation of various activities and projects under each ministry/department, detailed and updated information should be uploaded on the ministry/department's website, with an option for citizens to provide feedback.

6.6 Abolishing the Ministry of Armed Forces and Establishing a Joint Chiefs of Staff Board and Secretariat:

(a) It is recommended that the Armed Forces Division under the Prime Minister's Office be abolished and its activities transferred to the Ministry of Defense.

(b) A Joint Chiefs of Staff Board, consisting of the Army, Navy, and Air Force Chiefs, should be established for inter-service coordination. The Board's chair will rotate annually among the three service heads. Promotions in each service will occur through their respective promotion boards, but for the promotion to Brigadier General or higher positions, prior approval from the head of the government will be required.

6.7 Reorganization of the Internal Revenue Division: The role of the Secretary of the Internal Revenue Division and the Chairman of the Revenue Board should be separated. A dedicated Secretary will lead the Internal Revenue Division for revenue policy formulation, and the implementation will be handled by three departments: (1) Income Tax Department; (2) Customs and Excise Department; & (3) VAT Department. The Internal Revenue Division should be strengthened with specialized personnel. Separate Director-General positions should be created for each department, and a workforce restructuring should take place.

6.8 Separating the ICT Division: The Information and Communication Technology Division should be separated from the Ministry of Posts, Telecommunications, and ICT and merged with the Ministry of Science and Technology.

6.9 Reorganization of Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics: To enhance the credibility and efficiency of the Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics, it is recommended that it be transformed into the "Bangladesh Statistics Commission," with an independent legal framework.

6.10 Merging Investment and Development Authorities: The Bangladesh Investment and Development Authority currently performs similar roles as the Bangladesh Export Processing Zones Authority (BEPZA), the Economic Zones Authority, and the Export Development Bureau. It is recommended that these organizations be merged into the Bangladesh Investment and Development Authority.

6.11 Formation of Two New Divisions: Considering geographical and communication convenience, there have been long-standing demands for the formation of new divisions in Comilla and Faridpur. It is, therefore, recommended that these two new divisions be created.

6.12 Renaming District Commissioner and Upazila Executive Officer Positions: It is recommended that the titles "District Commissioner" and "Upazila Executive Officer" be changed to "Upazila Commissioner" and "District Magistrate & District

Commissioner," respectively. The title of "Additional District Commissioner (Revenue)" can be changed to "Additional District Commissioner (Land Management)."

6.13 Granting the District Magistrate the Power to Accept Cases: It is recommended that the District Commissioner be given authority to accept CR cases of certain types. He can instruct local officials or respected individuals to mediate or investigate the complaints. If the complaint is deemed valid after preliminary investigation, the District Magistrate can instruct the police to file a case. This will allow citizens to file cases more easily. Moreover, minor disputes can be resolved outside the courts, reducing the case load on the judiciary. However, complainants can still approach the courts if the case is not resolved. Supreme Court advice may be sought for further action in this regard.

6.14 Establishing Magistrate Courts at the Upazila Level: Establishing civil and criminal Magistrate Courts at the Upazila level would greatly benefit the public. The necessary steps can be taken after consulting the Supreme Court.

6.15 Assigning an Upazila Security Officer: To improve law and order, an Assistant Superintendent of Police (ASP) should be appointed as the "Upazila Security Officer" for monitoring the work and overall law enforcement at the Upazila level. This would improve the accountability of local police stations.

6.16 Appointment of Separate Immigration Officers: Immigration procedures at airports are currently handled by police officers, whose behavior is not always passenger-friendly. In many countries, separate immigration officers are appointed instead of police officers. It is recommended that Bangladesh also appoint qualified immigration officers, with 20% of them coming from police on deputations. These officers can be trained both domestically and internationally.

6.17 Reforming Land Registration Offices: Land Registration Offices currently operate under the Ministry of Law and Justice, while other land management offices fall under the Ministry of Land. The dual management system increases public inconvenience. It is recommended to transfer the land registration function entirely under the Ministry of Land.

6.18 Digitalization of Sub-Registry Offices: Currently, there is a lack of coordination between the Upazila Land Office and Sub-Registry Office. While the Land Office has introduced digital systems, the Sub-Registry Office has not. It is recommended that both offices be brought under the same ministry and the Sub-Registry Office should be digitalized to streamline land transaction processes.

6.19 Transfer of Marriage Registration Offices: The marriage registration offices should be placed under the jurisdiction of the District Commissioner. If there are any appeals, they can be resolved at the Divisional Commissioner level.

6.20 Introducing Provincial Governance System: (a) Given the increasing population and the expanding scope of government services, the current administrative structure appears insufficient. To decentralize services and reduce the concentration of power in the capital, it is proposed to divide the old four divisions into four provinces, thereby introducing a provincial governance system. This will reduce pressure on the central government and ease the burden on Dhaka.

(b) Considering the population and service needs of Dhaka, it is recommended to establish a 'Capital City Government' or a 'Federal Government-controlled Metropolitan Government' like New Delhi. This would include an elected assembly and local government, with a governance area covering Dhaka city, Tongi, Keraniganj, Savar, and Narayanganj. However, Dhaka and Narayanganj Districts will retain their current Upazila setup.

6.21 Abolition of District Councils: There has been ongoing debate regarding the continuation of district councils. Since the District Council Chairman is not directly elected by citizens and most councils lack strong revenue sources, it is proposed to abolish the District Councils and transfer their assets to the relevant provincial governments.

6.22 Strengthening Municipalities: To empower local governments, municipalities should be made stronger. The Mayor should be elected by the Ward Members, as once elected, a mayor tends to disregard the importance of the members.

6.23 Strengthening Upazila Councils:

(a) To further empower Upazila councils, it is proposed to abolish the post of Vice-Chairman.

(b) To make the Upazila council more representative, one-third of the members from Union Councils can be rotated.

(c) The Upazila Executive Officer should not be under the Upazila Council but should focus solely on legal and administrative matters such as law enforcement, land management, and mobile court operations. A Senior Assistant Secretary could be appointed as the Upazila Council Secretary.

(d) To improve land management, a second-tier land management officer position could be created at the Upazila level.

6.24 Reforming Union Councils: The number of wards in Union Councils should be adjusted to 9-11 based on population. Each ward will have two members, one of whom should be a female. This will ensure 50% representation for women and ensure their influence in their areas. The Union Council Chairman should be elected by the members.

6.25 Delegating More Responsibilities to Union Councils: (a) Union Councils could be given the responsibility for implementing informal and mosque-based education programs.

(b) Union councils could set up committees under the leadership of the Union Chairman for agricultural and water-related matters. Health and other service-related committees could also be formed. (c) Strengthening village courts or arbitration systems could reduce disputes at the grassroots level.

(d) Public consultations through town halls should be organized to form these committees and ensure public participation in their activities.

CHAPTER SEVEN: DISCUSSES RATIONALE FOR STRUCTURAL AND PROCEDURAL REFORMS IN THE CIVIL SERVICE

The chapter proposes the reform of the Integrated Cadre Services, aiming to enhance the efficiency and responsiveness of the civil service to the needs of the public. It also suggests the establishment of a "Superior Executive Service," which would ensure the appointment of qualified individuals to key administrative positions. Furthermore, the proposal includes the creation of multiple Public Service Commissions, each responsible for recruitment in specific sectors, thereby streamlining the hiring process. The introduction of multiple "Principal Secretary" positions is also recommended to strengthen leadership within government administration. Additionally, the chapter outlines measures to reduce the disparities between inter-cadre and cadre-non-cadre employees, promoting equality and fairness within the civil service. These reforms aim to improve the effectiveness of the civil service and enhance the government's service delivery mechanisms. The following recommendations are made in this chapter:

7.1 Restructuring of the Bangladesh Civil Service (BCS):

(a) The current "Cadre" system under the Bangladesh Civil Service (BCS) may be replaced with specialized designations, considering the nature of work and specific skill sets required for each service. It is proposed to divide the existing BCS cadres into the following 14 major services:

1. Bangladesh Administrative Service
2. Bangladesh Judicial Service
3. Bangladesh Public Security Service
4. Bangladesh Foreign Service
5. Bangladesh Accounts Service
6. Bangladesh Audit Service
7. Bangladesh Revenue Service
8. Bangladesh Engineering Service
9. Bangladesh Education Service
10. Bangladesh Health Service
11. Bangladesh Agricultural Service
12. Bangladesh Information Service
13. Bangladesh Railway Service
14. Bangladesh Information and Communication Technology Service

7.2 Splitting the BCS (Accounts and Audit) Service into Two Services: It is proposed to divide the BCS (Accounts and Audit) Service into two distinct services: one being the "Bangladesh Accounts Service" and the other the "Bangladesh Audit Service."

7.3 Restructuring of LGED and Public Health Engineering Department: The Commission recommends merging the engineers working in these two departments into a unified Engineering Service. Seniority among the officers concerned will be determined based on their joining dates.

7.4 Merging the Three Sub-Cadres under BCS (General Information): There are three sub-cadres under BCS (General Information) that have disparities in promotion opportunities. To eliminate these disparities, it is recommended to merge these three sub-cadres into one service with three distinct groups:

- a) Assistant Director/Information Officer/Research Officer
- b) Assistant Program Director
- c) Assistant News Controller

Promotion and postings for these roles can be based on the unified merit list.

7.5 Inclusion of ICT Officers into the Information Service: (a) While there has been progress in digital systems and ICT in various government departments, Bangladesh is still lagging in comparison to the international community. Many ICT officers in the public sector have shown exceptional talent, with some even succeeding internationally. In this context, it is recommended to include ICT officers into the Information and Communication Technology Service.

(b) The BCS (Information Engineering) Service should be included in the Information and Communication Technology Service.

7.6 Formation of the "Bangladesh Forest and Environment Service: The officers in the BCS (Forest) Service currently work under the Ministry of Forest and Environment. Given the increasing significance of climate change and environmental concerns, it is recommended to integrate the officers from the BCS (Forest) with those from the Environment Service into the "Bangladesh Forest and Environment Service" under the Bangladesh Agricultural Service.

7.7 Merging the BCS (Trade) with BCS (Customs and Excise): The BCS (Trade) Service, being a small service, is recommended for abolition and integration with the BCS (Customs and Excise) Service. As 80% of the WTO TFA provisions are implemented by the Customs Department, it is recommended that Trade Counselors in Bangladesh's diplomatic missions be appointed from the Customs Service. No new recruitment should be made into this service in the future.

7.8 Merging BCS (Food) and BCS (Cooperatives) with Bangladesh Administrative Service: It is proposed to merge the BCS (Food) and BCS (Cooperatives) with the Bangladesh Administrative Service. No new recruitment should be made for these two services in the future.

7.9 BCS (Postal) Service: Due to the ease of communication through the internet, social media, and courier services, the importance of the BCS (Postal) has significantly decreased. The government should assess whether it is necessary to gradually phase out this service.

7.10 Restructuring the Public Service Commission: After the independence of Bangladesh, two Public Service Commissions were created: one for Cadre Services and the other for Non-Cadre Services. Later, they were merged. Considering the overall situation, the Commission recommends establishing three Public Service Commissions for recruitment in public services:

- a) Bangladesh Public Service Commission (General)
- b) Bangladesh Public Service Commission (Education)
- c) Bangladesh Public Service Commission (Health)

The members of each Commission will consist of 8 members, including the Chairman. The Commission will oversee recruitment and promotion examinations, with separate examinations for education and health services. Officials from education and health services will also be eligible to participate in executive service recruitment exams.

7.11 Merit-Based Recruitment in Public Administration: A merit-based recruitment policy should be developed to ensure that recruitment and promotion processes are not easily altered. A specific timeline should be established for the recruitment process, especially for BCS exams, which currently take too long. It is recommended that the BCS exam be completed within a year. The process may be revised to focus on a comprehensive written exam. The PSC's annual examination schedule could be as follows:

- a) Notification: Second week of January
- b) Preliminary Exam: First week of April
- c) Preliminary Exam Results: First week of May
- d) Main Written Exam: Second half of June (10 days)
- e) Main Written Exam Results: Second week of December
- f) Oral and Psychological Exam: First week of January to second week of February
- g) Results: Third week of April
- h) Health and Police Clearance: Third week of May
- i) Appointment Order Gazette Publication: Second week of June
- j) Joining at Ministry: July 1st
- k) Foundation Training at PTC: First week of August

7.12 Written Exam Syllabus: (a) The syllabus for the main written exam in Bangladesh Civil Services may include the following six mandatory subjects:

- a) Bengali Composition – 100 marks
- b) English Composition – 100 marks
- c) English Composition and Presie – 100 marks
- d) Constitution, History, Tradition, and Culture of Bangladesh – 100 marks
- e) International and Current Affairs – 100 marks
- f) General Science and Technology, Society and Environment, and Geography – 100 marks

(b) In addition to mandatory subjects, 6 elective subjects or papers (each worth 100 marks) can be included from fields like arts, social sciences, physical sciences, commerce, and law. However, no more than two subjects can be selected from a single field. To assess problem-solving skills and psychological qualities, the exam format should be updated. An integrity exam may be introduced for initial screening. A minimum of 60% marks is recommended to pass the written and oral exams. The final results should be published along with the detailed breakdown of marks to ensure transparency. If a candidate fails the exam three times consecutively, they will be prohibited from taking the exam again.

7.13 Formation of a "Superior Executive Service" (SES): (a) A "Superior Executive Service" (SES) is recommended, consisting of the brightest and most capable officers from all services to fill positions from Deputy Secretary to Additional Secretary in the Secretariat. Since the civil service structure is pyramidal, not everyone can be promoted to top positions. It is suggested to provide an opportunity for the most capable individuals to ascend to higher positions through merit-based appointments, a practice followed in many countries.

(b) Opportunities for merit-based promotion in higher positions should be provided by reducing the quota for the administrative service from 75% to 50%, allowing the remaining 50% positions to be open for other services.

(c) The Public Service Commission will conduct competitive exams for the positions of Deputy Secretary, Joint Secretary, and Additional Secretary. The exam will give importance to talent and intellectual capacity, with at least 10 years of experience required for senior-scale officers from any service to apply.

7.14 Line Promotion for All Services: For officers of the Bangladesh Administrative Service who do not appear for or fail the SES exam to join the SES, they will still be eligible for line promotions in their respective services, such as the Additional Deputy Commissioner, District Magistrate, District Commissioner, Additional Divisional Commissioner, Divisional Commissioner, and Chief Commissioner posts. However, they will not receive positions equivalent to the SES in those services. On the other hand, for those promoted to the District Commissioner position, whether from the SES or other services, their percentages will be determined in proportion to the eligible candidates of the relevant service. The following diagram illustrates this proposal:

Table 10: Proposed Line Promotion for Various Services

Grade	Bangladesh Administrative Service	Superior Executive Service	Other Services (e.g., Health, Education, Agriculture, etc.)
Special	Not Applicable	Cabinet Secretary	Not Applicable
Special	Chief Commissioner	Principal Secretary	Head of the Relevant Service (e.g., Chief of Health Services)
Grade-1	Divisional Commissioner	Secretary	Director General
Grade-2	Additional Divisional Commissioner	Additional Secretary	Additional Director General
Grade-3	District Magistrate & District Commissioner	Joint Secretary	Director
Grade-5	Additional District Commissioner	Deputy Secretary	Additional Director
Grade-6	Senior Assistant Commissioner / Upazila Commissioner	Senior Assistant Secretary	Upazila Head
Grade-9	Assistant Commissioner	Assistant Secretary	Assistant Director

All line positions for each service must be arranged as shown above. Officers of each service will be promoted through exams for these positions. However, they may also participate in the SES exam for the Deputy Secretary post. Those not promoted to Deputy Secretary will advance in their respective line positions. Even if field and agency officers are promoted to line positions, they will not be equivalent to SES officers but will receive the same salary benefits.

7.15 Transfer and Appointment for Senior Positions: The positions currently held by Secretary-level officers in various services will be considered as departmental or field-level positions. All senior positions across services will be deemed equivalent in rank. For these positions, the Ministry of Public Administration will handle transfers, appointments, and promotions.

7.16 Mandatory Special Training before Promotion: Before each promotion step, it will be mandatory for an officer to undergo specific training for each level. For example, before becoming a Deputy Secretary, foundation and departmental courses must be completed; for Joint Secretary advanced courses (such as ACAD), and for Additional Secretary, courses like "Advanced Public Administration" must be completed. The officer must successfully complete the required training based on assessments before promotion.

7.17 Appointment of Secretary by Cabinet Committee: (a) A Cabinet Committee, under the leadership of a Minister, will select officers from Additional Secretaries to recommend the promotion of a secretary or Principal Secretary to the head of the government. The current Superior Selection Board may be abolished.

(b) For officers who may be appointed as Secretary from Additional Secretaries, provisions will be made for higher training so they may be qualified for leadership at the international level.

7.18 Salary Benefits in Case of No Promotion: If an employee reaches the highest level of promotion in any position, but does not receive an increment, and is not penalized in any departmental case, they will be recommended for the next salary scale every two years.

7.19 Lateral Recruitment: The government may recruit special qualified individuals on contract as Joint Secretaries or heads of agencies in 5% of positions outside the Superior Executive Service. However, this recruitment will be based on public notifications and evaluations by the Public Service Commission. Moreover, these recruits must complete at least a three-month orientation course before being assigned duties.

7.20 Appointment of Principal Secretary: In the case of restructuring ministries, multiple divisions will be created within them, and a secretary working in those ministries will be appointed as Principal Secretary. It is recommended that the current Senior

Secretary be appointed to this position. The current title "Senior Secretary" should be abolished. There will be no salary grade or scale for the Cabinet Secretary, and Principal Secretary positions. Their salaries and benefits will be determined by the government.

7.21 Ensuring Line Promotion in All Cadres: To resolve complaints of disparity among services, especially for those services without positions in grades 1-4, it is recommended that the necessary number of positions in grades 1-4 be created where applicable. Similarly, positions for promotions in various grades should be created in proportion to the demands of each service. Public Service Commission exams/assessments will be conducted for promotions to positions equivalent to grades 5 and 3.

7.22 Promotions Only Against Vacant Positions: It has been observed that promotions are often given to more positions than are vacant, creating complications. It is recommended that promotions be given only for positions that are vacant.

7.23 Legislation for Field Administration: Bangladesh's field administration follows the traditions and regulations from the British India and Pakistan eras. However, while India and Pakistan have separate laws for field administration, Bangladesh does not. It is recommended that a specific law for field administration be enacted to address issues of coordination between various government departments

7.24 Non-Cadre Officers' Participation in SES Exam: Non-cadre officers with a minimum of 3.5 GPA in their undergraduate and master's degrees and at least 15 years of work experience should be allowed to participate in the Deputy Secretary promotion exam.

7.25 Recruitment of Officers on Deputation: It is recommended that no officer should be appointed on deputation in any organization if there are qualified officers available within that organization. Moreover, the commission believes that it is not appropriate to appoint officers from the military to civilian positions on deputation, although this condition will not apply to retired military officers.

7.26 Assigning Current Duties: If an officer is qualified for promotion in any position, they should be promoted without being assigned to current duties. However, if no eligible officer is available for promotion, a senior officer may be assigned current charges.

7.27 Transfer of Powers to Appoint Employees: Except for first-class officers, it is recommended that district heads of relevant departments should have the power to transfer employees at the Upazila level. Similarly, departmental heads should have the power to transfer departmental employees

7.28 Vehicle Purchase Loan for Government Officers: Currently, there is a provision for vehicle purchase loans for Deputy Secretaries at the Secretariat and a monthly allowance for vehicle maintenance. However, this provision is not available for officers from other services. It is recommended to cancel this provision to reduce inequity and save government expenditure.

7.29 Determining Salary Scales: The Ministry of Finance may increase the basic salary annually based on inflation and the cost of living, as analyzed through Bangladesh Bank's provided index, but it should not exceed 5%. A permanent salary commission may be established for this purpose.

7.30 Permission for Retirement: It is recommended that government employees be allowed to retire with full benefits after 15 years of service. This will provide a pathway for officers opting for a career change.

7.31 Abolishing Mandatory Retirement after 25 Years of Service: It is recommended to abolish the provision under Public Service Act, 2018, section 45, which allows the government to mandate retirement after 25 years of service. This change will help ensure impartial public administration.

7.32 Officers on Special Duty (OSD): It is recommended that no officer/employee be placed on OSD without specific charges. If an officer is placed on OSD, a work plan should be created for them, with the possibility of temporary assignments to teaching or training positions.

7.33 Appointments in the Secretariat: Officers who have worked as Senior Assistant Secretaries for at least two years should be given priority for postings at the Upazila level or equivalent positions.

7.34 Promotion to Senior Assistant Secretary: It is recommended that Assistant Commissioners who have worked in the field for at least four years be promoted to Senior Assistant Secretary through merit-based exams.

7.35 Drug Addiction Test as Part of Health Check: It is recommended that candidates be tested for drug addiction during their health check after the results of Public Service Commission exams.

7.36 Appointment of Women in Block Positions: It is recommended to give priority to women for appointment to block positions. Male employees at the Upazila level may be transferred to other Upazilas.

7.37 Recruitment to Second and Third-Class Positions: If a provincial government system is implemented, a Provincial Recruitment Commission may be established to recruit for second and third-class positions in the government.

7.38 Reluctance of Employees at the Upazila Level: There have been complaints regarding negligence of duty and poor behavior towards citizens among second, third, and fourth-class employees at the field level. A monitoring committee should be formed under the leadership of the Upazila Executive Officer, consisting of the Officer in Charge of Police, Upazila Health Administrator, Upazila Education Officer, and Assistant Commissioner.

7.39 Career Planning in Public Administration: To transform public administration into an efficient and dynamic institution, it is recommended to restructure the career planning division with suitable officers and specialists.

CHAPTER EIGHT: REFORMS FOR TRANSPARENT AND ACCOUNTABLE PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

The chapter discusses various aspects of reforms aimed at improving accountability, transparency, and governance in Bangladesh's public administration. Here are the key points and recommendations summarized:

8.1 Strengthening the Office of the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG): To ensure transparency in public administration, guarantee the independence of audits, separate auditing from the accounting department, and improve the quality of audits, it is also recommended that an Audit Act be enacted. Previous commissions have also recommended separating the existing accounting and auditing departments of the Republic. The current commission has reiterated this recommendation.

8.2 Separation of Audit and Accounts Cadre: An initiative can be taken to separate the officers and employees of all levels, as well as the Audit and Accounts departments, both administratively and based on job specification. This division would ensure that the audit and accounting functions are clearly distinct and operate independently from one another.

8.3 After the Separation of Audit and Accounts Department: After the separation of the Audit and Accounts departments, no officer or employee at any level will have the opportunity for appointment, transfer, or posting between the two departments. To ensure equality between the separate Audit and Accounts department at various levels, the creation of some additional posts may be necessary. Additionally, non-cadre officers in the first and second grades, as well as employees at all levels in the third and fourth grades, can be permanently assigned to the Audit and Accounts departments based on the current staffing numbers. However, after the separation, there will be no opportunity for recruitment, transfer, or exchange between the Audit and Accounts departments.

8.4 Submission of Accounts Reports: The proposed audit law can establish a fixed deadline for submitting audit and audited account reports each year, specifying a particular month for the submission. This will ensure timely reporting and accountability in the audit process.

8.5 Independent Secretariat for C&AG: The proposed law should establish an independent secretariat for the Comptroller and Auditor General, freeing it from the administrative control of the Ministry of Finance. This will ensure greater autonomy and impartiality in the audit process, promoting transparency and efficiency.

8.6 Auditing Local Govt. Institutions: Since local government institutions use public funds, it is proposed that the audit of their activities should be carried out by the Audit Department. This will ensure transparency and accountability in the use of government resources by these institutions.

8.7 Coordination by Ministry of Finance: After the separation of the Audit and Accounts Departments, the CGA (Comptroller General of Accounts), CGDF (Comptroller General of Defense), and the Railway Accounts Department will remain under the Ministry of Finance. The Comptroller General of Accounts (CGA), on behalf of the Ministry of Finance, will be responsible for coordinating the accounts of the Civil, Defense, and Railway Departments and preparing the national financial accounts. This structure will ensure better coordination and management of financial records and reports.

8.8 Financial Management Academy: The Financial Management Academy (FIMA) will remain under the administrative control of the Auditor General. However, the training of officers and staff at all levels from the Accounts and Audit departments can continue as it currently does within FIMA.

8.9 Chairpersons of the Public Accounts Committee: The permanent committees related to various ministries in the National Parliament and the Public Accounts Committee may be made more effective. Opposition MPs may be appointed as chairpersons of the PAC and other important committees.

8.10 Effectiveness of Standing Committees: To strengthen the effectiveness of Standing Committees of the parliament different logistic supports should be made e.g. office accommodation, transport, research personnel and support staff.

8.11 Monitoring of Budget Implementation & Reporting to Parliament: According to Public Finance and Budget Management Act 2009 Section (15) 4, it is mandatory for the Minister of Finance to prepare a quarterly report of government income and expenditure and submit it to the next parliament session. However, it has not been followed for long time. The commission recommends that the Ministry of Finance should prepare a quarterly report of government income and expenditure and submit it to the next parliament session as per the provision of the relevant law.

8.12 Strengthening of Institute of Public Finance: There was no research and training organization for providing training for a huge number of officials working in different ministries, divisions, directorates outside the Audit and Accounts departments. Considering its importance, Institute of Public Finance was established. The commission recommends to establish a permanent campus and appoint qualified faculty for the institute.

8.13 Introduction of Performance-based Budget: The commission recommends Finance Division to prepare a time bound work plan for transforming traditional approach for assesment of budgetary performance in terms of expenditure and efficiency to a performance-based budgetary system.

8.14 Strengthening the Anti-Corruption Commission (ACC): The Anti-Corruption Commission (ACC) should be declared an autonomous institution, enabling it to formulate its own rules and regulations. The Commission may be granted full independence in the recruitment of its officers at all levels. This will empower the ACC to operate more effectively in combating corruption and ensure greater accountability within the system.

8.15 Strengthening the Bangladesh Information Commission: To make the Bangladesh Information Commission a more effective organization, the process of selecting its chairman and members should be conducted through a selection committee. To ensure full independence of the Commission, a judge from the High Court Division of the Supreme Court (with no prior affiliations) may be appointed as the head of the Information Commission. The Commission's branch offices may be expanded up to the administrative division level. A provision should be made to allow citizens to appeal to the Divisional Information Commissioner, if they are unable to easily access information as required.

8.16 Establishment of the Office of Ombudsman: An Ombudsman may be appointed from among the judges of the Supreme Court or, in consultation with the Supreme Court, from a neutral individual of equivalent status. According to Article 77 of the Constitution, the appointment of an Ombudsman for the country should be made as quickly as possible. The Ombudsman Act of 1980 can be amended, and an ordinance issued to enable the appointment of the Ombudsman by the President.

8.17 Grivance Redress System (GRS): After the establishment of the Ombudsman (Nayapal) office, the responsibility for complaint resolution, monitoring, and implementation of all necessary activities in ministries and all government departments will be entrusted to the Ombudsman's office.

8.18 Implementation of a New Performance Management System in Government Offices: Each ministry, department, directorate, and other government institutions will align their 'Organizational Charter' or the structure of their operations and 'Table

of Organization and Equipment' (TO&E) with their vision and mission. A clear description of responsibilities and duties for each position, regardless of rank or level, must be prepared and documented for every government office and institution. Each ministry and department should develop a performance process framework, known as SOP (Standard Operating Procedure). Before creating the SOP, the Cabinet Division should review the Secretariat's guidelines and rules, updating them as necessary.

8.19 Introduction of a New Performance Evaluation System for Government Employees: Instead of the current Annual Confidential Report (ACR), a new Annual Performance Review (APR) system should be implemented. At the beginning of the year, each officer will submit their annual work plan to the supervising officer. At the end of the year, senior officers will evaluate the employees' performance based on the submitted plan. This evaluation will be conducted through mutual discussions.

The performance of employees will be assessed in four categories: Unsatisfactory, Satisfactory, Good, and Excellent. Based on their performance, employees may receive financial benefits, training, and other opportunities. Similarly, the organization may receive budget increases or special privileges based on its annual performance.

However, if an employee receives unsatisfactory performance ratings for two consecutive years, his/her promotion may be halted, and if an organization receives unsatisfactory ratings for two consecutive years, it may face restrictions on purchasing office vehicles or furniture.

8.20 Annual Work Plan and Performance Evaluation for Government Offices/Organizations: The head of each organization will prepare an annual work plan and submit it to the higher authorities at the beginning of the year. The organization's performance evaluation can be carried out either internally or through external authorities. The current Annual Performance Agreement (APA) system may be maintained, but it can be strengthened by ensuring independent evaluation processes. Based on performance, there may be provisions for budget increases or special benefits for the organization. This system aims to enhance accountability and performance within government offices and organizations, ensuring that resources are allocated effectively based on results.

8.21 Publication of Annual Report by Ministries/Departments and Offices:

Each ministry and department will be required to publish an annual performance report, which should be made publicly available on their respective websites. This report may include sections on laws and regulations, financial statements, environmental pollution, health services, crime control, and other matters of national importance. The report will highlight key activities implemented in the previous year, achievements, financial income and expenditure, and special accomplishments. This initiative will promote transparency in governance and ensure accountability in the administration, allowing citizens and stakeholders to evaluate the performance of public institutions.

8.22 Open Data Policy: The Government of Bangladesh may consider adopting an open data policy as it will enhance transparency and accountability while helping to combat corruption. Reforms to the Right to Information (RTI) Act have been recommended in previous chapters. To ensure the free flow of information, the Official Secrets Act 1923, and the Evidence Act 1872 may be revised and updated accordingly. It is also essential to guarantee the freedom and security of the press and media, ensuring their impartial, truth-seeking, objective, and responsible reporting. Journalists should be encouraged to publish investigative reports that contribute to public awareness and accountability.

8.23 Appointment of 'Administrative Ombudsman': To ensure transparency and accountability in administrative matters, an 'Administrative Ombudsman' can be appointed as soon as possible. Instead of waiting for a law to be passed in the National Parliament, the President may issue an ordinance for the appointment of the Administrative Ombudsman. This would allow for immediate action and the establishment of the required framework to enhance the efficiency and accountability of the administrative processes.

8.24 Process Reforms for Ensuring Accountability in Public Administration:

- a) The annual budget of all government ministries and departments must be easily accessible and open to the public.
- b) Measures should be taken to ensure complete transparency and adherence to fair policies in the government procurement process.
- c) Government audit activities should be carried out regularly, and the audit department must be strengthened. Audit reports should be made available to the public.

- d) Regular public hearings should be conducted to assess citizen satisfaction with government services and to address any complaints. The same recommendation was made in the previous section.
- e) Efforts should be made to build and popularize an administrative culture that ensures transparency and accountability. It may be made mandatory for every government employee to submit an annual statement of their assets in accordance with the law. The submitted asset declarations may be made open for public viewing.
- f) Whistleblowers should be encouraged in uncovering unethical, illegal, and corrupt activities. They should be provided with protection through legislation and safeguarded from all forms of harassment.
- g) The administrative tribunal should be further strengthened by providing additional personnel and logistics.
- h) A separate prosecution department for criminal cases may be established. Another prosecution department for civil cases related to government assets and interests may be established.
- i) A separate tribunal may be established for land-related cases.

CHAPTER NINE: REFORMS TO ENSURE NEUTRALITY IN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

The chapter discusses the importance of a neutral civil service, the techniques used to politicize public administration, areas and challenges of politicization, and the cessation of intelligence reports regarding recruitment and promotion in public administration. The following recommendations are presented:

9.1 Establishment of an Independent Investigation Commission: It is recommended to establish an independent commission to investigate civil servants involved in election fraud, money laundering, corruption, and the 2024 July-August genocide, which have severely damaged the professionalism, image, and democratic processes of public administration. There is significant public support for this action.

9.2 Police Verification: It is recommended to abolish the practice of asking political affiliations during police verification for promotions. Politicization in public administration often begins at this level. No police verification should take place before the announcement of written and oral exam results. After a candidate passes the BCS exam, only a police report on any criminal case against the individual will be requested before final appointment by the Ministry of Public Administration. Additionally, verification on matters such as passports, dual citizenship, or NGO board memberships should be abolished. Verification should be handled by the ministry where the candidate joins.

9.3 Voluntary Retirement after 15 Years of Service: It is recommended to amend Section 45 of the Civil Service Act, 2018, to remove the mandatory retirement rule after 25 years of service. However, it should be allowed for any civil servant to voluntarily retire after 15 years of service.

9.4 Political Activity Participation: It is recommended that civil servants should not participate in political rallies or protests organized by any political party. Associations under various services should refrain from using political affiliations to criticize government decisions or organize protests. If an individual feels discriminated against, they may file a complaint through the legal framework.

9.5 Ensuring Safety of Government Employees: The safety, dignity, and financial security of civil servants must be guaranteed to ensure that they can perform their duties impartially and honestly without fear of harassment. This can be added to the Civil Servants' Protection Act, 2018.

9.6 Appointment of Minister's Private Secretaries (PS) and Assistant Private Secretaries: It has been observed that many civil servants who served as Private Secretaries to ministers have been subjected to harassment or missed promotions in subsequent governments. To avoid such situations, it is suggested that the positions of Private Secretary and Assistant Private Secretary be filled by individuals from outside the civil service, as per the preference of the ministers.

9.7 Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) Clear Guidelines for Political Interference in Administrative Decisions:

It is a regular matter for public administration to make decisions on legal and policy matters. Sometimes unethical and illegal political interference disturbs the decision making processes. It results in injustice, prevent public interests and ultimately mistrust on public administration. To prevent political interference in administrative decisions, clear boundaries should be set between the

duties of civil servants and elected representatives. Ministries, departments, or offices should delineate responsibilities in accordance with legal frameworks and institutional policies specially Rules of Business and Standard Operating Procedure.

9.8 Policy Formulation and Implementation: Civil servants should prepare work plans and carry out tasks based on existing regulations, while elected representatives should ensure that public services meet the expectations of the people and the government. Legislative standing committees should oversee the formulation and implementation of necessary policies.

9.9 Scope of Responsibilities for Elected Representatives: Elected representatives should not interfere in the administrative tasks of civil servants. Any minister, member of parliament, or political figure who exerts undue pressure on civil servants for illegal actions must report this to the Cabinet Secretary. Written orders should be given for any changes in official decisions, and oral instructions should not be implemented.

9.10 Anti-Corruption Measures in Public Administration: a) All government officials, ministers, deputy ministers, and members of parliament should submit an annual asset declaration to the relevant department, which should be made publicly available online. (b) Strengthening the existing National Integrity System (NIS) is essential. (c) To curb favoritism, civil servants should not serve in their own administrative departments, and the policy of transferring officers every three years to prevent corruption should be strictly enforced.

CHAPTER TEN: DEVELOPMENT OF COMPETENCE AND CAPABILITY IN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

The chapter discusses the framework for enhancing skills and training, as well as professional development, in public administration. The following recommendations are presented:

10.1 Lack of Coordination Among Training Centers: It is recommended to establish an independent training commission comprising experts to improve coordination among all government training institutions and to promote excellence in training. This commission will ensure the autonomy of various institutions, provide structural reforms, and offer guidance on curriculum development and training methods.

10.2 Determining Training Needs: The need for training (TN) should be assessed and regularly evaluated to identify areas where training benefits can be maximized and improvements can be made. TN will help identify the underlying causes of skill deficiencies among government employees.

10.3 Foundation Training: The Bangladesh Public Administration Training Center (BPATC) should be developed as a Center of Excellence for basic training for all civil servants, ensuring uniform and appropriate training for newly recruited officers in all services and reducing disparities. However, BPATC in Savar cannot provide basic training for all services simultaneously; therefore, three underutilized institutions of the Bangladesh Rural Development Academy in Gopalganj, Jamalpur, and Rangpur should be designated as regional BPATCs and provide basic training using the same modules. The syllabus for basic training should be reviewed and updated as necessary.

10.4 Collaboration with Training Academies: A strong collaborative framework should be developed with various training academies. Each ministry should establish direct relationships with relevant universities to foster research and other activities. To ensure the most effective use of resources, opportunities for higher education abroad should be more strategically aligned.

10.5 Provision of Higher Degrees: In addition to pursuing higher education at renowned global universities, it is recommended that a strategic management approach be adopted to offer higher degrees, such as master's programs, through local universities with faculty members holding foreign degrees. The government could offer scholarships for such programs, which would save foreign exchange while also enhancing knowledge exchange between educational institutions and civil services. International trips, carefully planned to enhance the program's effectiveness, should be incorporated to give civil servants insight into international systems and best practices, which would be cost-effective.

10.6 Advanced Training: In addition to BPATC's existing three basic training programs, such as administrative training, officers can also receive regular training on skills enhancement based on specific TN areas. Training applications can be solicited from

officials, their evaluations and feedback on online training curricula can be gathered, allowing participants to choose convenient training times and continuously upgrade their skills.

10.7 Considering Training Success: Currently, the success of training is not considered when making decisions about transfers, promotions, and career planning. As a result, employees are not motivated to take training seriously, even when they participate. Integrating training with career development will help change this attitude. The success of training should be recorded in government employees' personal files and should be considered when promoting professionalism in government service.

10.8 Priority-Based Training: In addition to general and technical training for government employees, the following priority training should be given to district and upazila officials to ensure their proficiency in using technology for administrative tasks:

- a) Basic digital literacy and IT skills
- b) E-Governance systems and portals
- c) Data management and digital record-keeping
- d) Cybersecurity awareness
- e) Communication and collaboration tools
- f) Citizen-centric service delivery
- g) Disaster response and management (Medium-term)

CHAPTER ELEVEN: EFFICIENCY IN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

The chapter discusses the main challenges in achieving efficiency and effectiveness in public administration and presents the following recommendations:

11.1 Efficiency in Service Delivery:

- (a) **Defining Service Standards:** Each ministry should establish standards and benchmarks for citizen services. A system for collecting citizens' feedback can be implemented to improve the quality of services. (Medium-term)
- (b) **Online Tracking System:** An online tracking system can be established to measure delays in various public services. The total time taken to deliver a service can be combined with an employee's efficiency to evaluate performance. (Medium-term)
- (c) **Citizen Charter:** A Citizen Charter, which sets forth the commitment of public offices to provide services, should be updated and strictly implemented. All services provided by public offices/ministries should be clearly mentioned and be somewhat measurable. (Medium-term)
- (d) **Simplifying the Service Delivery Process:** Government employees who take important steps to simplify processes and reduce public hassle should be encouraged, and such initiatives should be recognized to motivate others. (Medium-term)
- (e) **'System-Based Token':** In offices where large crowds typically gather for service, a system-based token system could be introduced to maintain order. (Medium-term)
- (f) **Adherence to Service Delivery Time:** The standard service delivery time for each service must be adhered to. In case of delays or rejections, the service applicant should be informed promptly. (Medium-term)
- (g) **Evaluation of Service Delivery Efficiency or Failure:** The internal audit team of the organization should independently evaluate the efficiency or failure of service delivery and submit an annual report to the minister responsible. This report should be a public document. (Medium-term)
- (h) **Reasonable Budget and Expenditure:** Each service's budget allocation and expenditure should be reasonable, and a culture of providing services at affordable costs should be promoted. (Medium-term)

11.2 Streamlining the Decision-Making Process: Since the decision-making/approval process passes through many levels, the effective delegation of administrative and financial powers should be strictly followed. Clear guidelines and policies must be formulated for administrative procedures. A map of administrative processes should be created to identify unnecessary steps and

bottlenecks. The decision-making procedures in ministries should be simplified, and most decisions should be made below the joint secretary level. If necessary, the power delegation process should be reviewed to allow routine/regular decisions to be made by joint secretaries or below. A single service center (e.g., One-Stop Service Center) could be established to reduce bureaucratic complexity. (Medium-term)

11.3 Digital Transformation:

- (a) **Basic Evaluation of Existing Digital Services:** A basic evaluation/survey of existing digital services should be conducted to identify issues related to e-governance.
- (b) **National E-Governance Strategy:** A national e-governance strategy should be developed with clear goals for accessibility and efficiency.
- (c) **Investment in Digital Infrastructure:** Investments should be made in digital infrastructure for online service delivery (e.g., portals, mobile apps). (Medium-term)
- (d) **Creation of a Unified National Digital Infrastructure Database:** A unified national digital infrastructure database should be created, aligned with the needs of each ministry/department/agency.

11.4 Inter-Ministerial Coordination:

- (a) Inter-ministerial coordination is a major challenge. To address this, it is recommended to introduce an integrated public service platform based on a web portal with interconnectivity. The central web portal should connect with local e-governance initiatives. Decentralized service delivery centers should be empowered.
- (b) The digital tracking system should allow all relevant officials to provide decisions/opinions. There should be access to data and interconnectivity for data sharing. Government employees should be trained in digital tools and platforms.
- (c) The web portal should ensure citizen participation and allow feedback responses from the government.
- (d) To effectively follow the digital tracking system, the capacity of institutions, agencies, and human resources must be strengthened. Additionally, a system for monitoring and evaluating the performance of officers and employees should be implemented to ensure the standardization of administrative processes. Investment should be made in training and capacity-building programs for public service employees. (Medium-term)

11.5 Compensation Claims for Service Applicants: A predefined simple process should be established for service applicants to claim compensation from the ministry/department responsible for any harassment during service delivery. (Medium-term)

11.6 Effective Power Delegation: Since there are many layers in the decision-making process, effective delegation of administrative (and financial) powers should be strictly followed, and most decisions should be made below the joint secretary level. (Medium-term)

11.7 Performance-Based Management:

- (a) A key performance indicator (KPI) should be introduced to evaluate the efficiency of government employees.
- (b) A regular performance review and feedback mechanism should be implemented.
- (c) A reward system could be established for high performance and innovative service.
- (d) Performance-based evaluation should be used to assess policies and programs annually. (Medium-term)

11.8 Reform Methods and Change Process:

- (a) Local officers should be trained in customer service and public relations to enhance their professionalism and sense of responsibility toward public service.
- (b) Workshops and public outreach programs can be conducted to increase citizens' digital knowledge.
- (c) Collaboration with technology providers should be encouraged to create affordable digital solutions for local governance.

- (d) Social media and mobile apps should be promoted to ease communication between citizens and local governments.
- (e) Training on performance management should be provided to local government leaders to foster a culture of accountability.
- (f) Partnerships with NGOs and civil society organizations can improve service quality.
- (g) Community-based feedback mechanisms should be established to gather effective responses and assess service satisfaction.

CHAPTER TWELVE: REFORMS FOR THE EFFECTIVENESS OF PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

The rationale for reforms is discussed below in relation to the role of public administration in delivering citizen services, the effectiveness of those services, and the prevalence of bureaucratic red tape. The following recommendations have been proposed:

12.1 Streamlining Bureaucratic Processes

- a) **Simplifying and digitizing administrative procedures for citizen service delivery:** This is crucial to enhance the efficiency of public administration.
- b) **Analyzing data and statistics impartially:** This will aid in accurate policymaking and presenting relevant information to policymakers.
- c) **Allocating state resources based on the needs and evidence of target populations:** This should be done with clear, data-driven criteria.
- d) **Establishing one-stop service centers:** These centers should be easily accessible to citizens for various government services.
- e) **Implementing a dynamic system for citizen feedback:** A system should be in place that allows citizens to provide feedback and feel heard.

12.2 Adoption and Application of Technology in Operations

- a) **Reviewing and revising administrative regulations, departmental allocations, and secretariat directives:** These should be made available online for easier access.
- b) **Dividing ministries and departments into five clusters:** This proposal aims to improve efficiency, as mentioned in previous sections.
- c) **Creating a central online portal for government services:** A single online platform will streamline access to services.
- d) **Implementing e-governance strategies:** This will help in modernizing service delivery and increasing efficiency.
- e) **Investing in training for employees:** A focus on digital tools and data management will enhance the workforce's capabilities.
- f) **Introducing a digital public administration system:** This will involve citizens in the process, ensuring better governance.

12.3 Diversity and Inclusion

- a) **Prioritizing women and marginalized groups in service delivery and resource allocation:** Special focus should be given to these groups to ensure inclusivity.
- b) **Raising awareness about diversity and inclusion among government employees:** This will foster a more inclusive working environment.

- c) **Ensuring that resources reach marginalized communities:** It's essential to ensure that these groups can access services effectively.

12.4 Decentralization and Strengthening Local Government in Environmental Management

- a) **Implementing environmental protection and development laws:** Relevant laws should be enforced effectively to protect ecosystems.
- b) **Conduct environmental surveys before initiating projects:** This will ensure that the environmental impact is assessed.
- c) **Empowering local government and district administrations:** Strengthening coordination between various ministries and departments will improve environmental management.
- d) **Transferring environmental service delivery to local governments:** This will allow local administrations to handle services effectively.

12.5 Climate Change Adaptation

- a) **Integrating national climate change strategies into government policies:** This should be done to ensure alignment with broader goals.
- b) **Conducting research and surveys on climate change impacts:** Local context should be considered when assessing climate risks.
- c) **Allocating resources for climate change mitigation projects:** These projects should be prioritized across different government levels.

12.6 Disaster Management

- a) **Strengthening the national disaster response framework:** This will enhance preparedness and response to natural disasters.
- b) **Allocating adequate funds for disaster preparedness and risk mitigation:** Timely and reasonable funding should be provided to manage disaster risks.
- c) **Expanding collaboration with international organizations and NGOs:** This will strengthen disaster response capabilities.

12.7 Establishing a Stronger Network Between Districts, Upazilas, and the Center

- a) **Connecting local e-governance systems to the central web portal and mobile connectivity:** This integration will improve the accessibility and coordination of services.
- b) **Placing service delivery points in accessible locations:** Special attention should be given to farmers, women, and other vulnerable groups to ensure easy access to services.
- c) **Providing technical training for employees:** Employees involved in digital service delivery must be adequately trained in relevant technologies.

These recommendations aim to enhance the effectiveness of public administration and improve service delivery to citizens through systematic reforms, technological integration, and a focus on inclusivity and decentralization.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN: SPECIAL RECOMMENDATIONS FOR THE REFORM OF BANGLADESH HEALTH SERVICES

The chapter highlights the various aspects of public health services, workforce involvement, the need for reforms, and improvements in health management. The following key recommendations are proposed:

13.1 Establishment of Public Service Commission (Health): A separate **Public Service Commission (Health)** is recommended for the recruitment, promotion exams, and other operations of the **Bangladesh Health Service**, replacing the BCS (Health) cadre. A high-level task force should be formed for detailed work plan.

13.2 Reorganization of the Structure of Health Service Workforce: The structure of health service workforce should be redefined through a committee initiated by the Ministry of Health, considering the importance of large-scale staffing. The proposed recommendations should be submitted to the Permanent Public Administration Reform Commission.

13.3 Restructuring of the Directorate General of Health Services: Restructuring of the Directorate General of Health Services is necessary to align with workforce changes. This will resolve long-term human resource issues, improve efficiency, and strengthen the health service, education, and public health systems.

13.4 Career Planning and Deputation Policy: A career planning strategy should be formulated for all levels of health service staff. Additionally, the deputation policy should consider MBBS results, performance during internships and village service, demand-based specialization, and the candidate's preferences.

13.5 Line Promotions: A clear pathway for line promotions should be established across three divisions (health service, health education, and health management), with further discussions required on the relationships between these positions.

13.6 Access to the Superior Executive Service: Health service officials should have the opportunity to compete in exams for entry into the **Superior Executive Service**, as recommended by the Public Administration Reform Commission.

13.7 Increase in the Age Limit for Initial Recruitment: The government may consider increasing the age limit for initial recruitment in the Bangladesh Health Service by two years.

13.8 Rationalization of Medical Colleges and Student Numbers: The number of medical colleges and students should be rationalized based on the country's population and geographical considerations. Quality improvement efforts for existing colleges are also necessary.

13.9 Separation of Organizational and Staffing Structures for Academic and Service Hospitals: Health service and health education should be fully separated, dividing hospitals into academic and service categories for better management and control.

13.10 Specialized Medical Institutions Outside Dhaka: Establishment of specialized medical institutions should be prioritized outside Dhaka to improve healthcare access in other regions.

13.11 Appointment of Skilled and Adequate Staff: Before establishing new medical institutions, it is crucial to ensure that skilled and qualified personnel are appointed to these institutions.

13.12 Ensuring Attendance: A digital attendance system should be implemented, and physical monitoring should be enhanced to ensure employee presence. Strict actions must be taken against unauthorized absences.

13.13 Appointment of Doctors in Rural Areas: To address challenges in rural areas, a policy should be developed to encourage doctors' presence, incorporating e-logbook evaluations. Strategic workforce planning can help balance rural service needs with healthcare demand.

13.14 Training Policy: A training policy should be established to ensure health officials receive training according to national health priorities, not based on personal preferences.

13.15 Greater Autonomy for Specialized Medical Institutions: Specialized medical institutions should be given more autonomy, with the necessary legislative frameworks developed.

13.16 CSR Programs: Pharmaceutical industries could be encouraged to donate free medicines to government hospitals as part of their Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR).

13.17 Budget Allocation Based on Patient Numbers: Government hospitals should receive budget allocations based on the number of patients treated, rather than the number of beds.

13.18 Eradication of Middlemen: Effective measures should be taken to eliminate the influence of middlemen in government and private hospitals. Automated systems should be implemented to track patient numbers daily.

13.19 Health Protection Law: A Health Protection Law should be introduced to balance the interests of doctors, health workers, and patients.

13.20 Quality Control of Laboratories: A regulatory authority should be established to ensure the quality control of health service laboratories.

13.21 Establishment of Training Institutes: Training institutes should be set up to provide specialized training to health professionals involved in both health services and education.

13.22 Creation of Physiotherapy Departments and Posts: Physiotherapy departments and positions for physiotherapists should be established in all public medical colleges, specialized hospitals, and district hospitals.

13.23 Management of Community Health Centers: Private sector organizations could be entrusted with the management of community health centers in rural areas, with the government providing budget support based on certain criteria.

These recommendations aim to address key issues in Bangladesh's health sector, focusing on improving service quality, workforce management, training, infrastructure, and healthcare access.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN: SPECIAL RECOMMENDATIONS FOR REFORM OF THE EDUCATION SERVICE:

It suggests the renaming of the BCS (Education) cadre to an independent "Bangladesh Education Service" and the establishment of a separate Bangladesh Education Service Commission to handle recruitment, placement, promotion, training, and other related tasks. The following recommendations are made:

14.1 Formation of the Bangladesh Education Service Commission: The previous chapter of the report recommends abolishing the BCS cadre and renaming it according to the service's specific characteristics. Therefore, the "Bangladesh Education Service" will be established, and a separate Bangladesh Public Service Commission (Education) should be set up for handling recruitment, promotion, and other examination-related tasks.

14.2 Regular Promotion System: A recommendation is made to ensure a regular promotion system for BCS General Education cadre officers, enabling them to progress from the 9th grade to the 1st grade. A promotion policy based on competence, efficiency, experience, and educational qualifications should be formulated, with examinations or evaluation methods administered by the newly formed Education Service Commission. At least 5% of professors should be promoted to the second grade of the national pay scale, particularly those who hold a Ph.D. and have five years of experience as professors.

14.3 Mandatory Research: To create quality teachers, it is recommended that associate professors must complete at least three original research works, and professors must complete at least five research projects. The research must be published in national and international indexed journals.

14.4 Undergraduate and Postgraduate Education Administration: There are over 2200 colleges in Bangladesh offering undergraduate and postgraduate education, with seven colleges in Dhaka under the National University. The administration of these colleges is managed by the National University, which resembles the role of secondary and higher secondary education boards. The report recommends affiliating degree-level colleges in various districts and divisions with local public universities.

14.5 Selection of a Principal College in Each Division and District: The recommendation is to select one leading college in each division and district and transform them into specialized institutions for higher education, making them closer to university-level institutions. These colleges should undergo rapid institutional and human resource assessments, and necessary investments should be made to enhance their capabilities. Professors with Ph.D. degrees and research publications should be appointed to these institutions.

14.6 Establishment of a Separate Secondary Education Directorate: It is proposed that the Secondary Education Department be separated from the Department of Secondary and Higher Education to ensure the focus and importance of secondary education. The establishment of an independent Secondary Education Directorate is essential.

14.7 Establishment of a College Education Directorate: It is suggested that a separate Directorate of College Education be formed, with the Director-General's post elevated to Grade-1.

14.8 Introduction of Honors Programs at the College Level: The report suggests introducing honors programs at the college level to end dual governance and improve coordination. A committee led by the Secretary of Education should recommend steps for introducing honors programs, and the expansion of honors programs in private colleges should be limited.

14.9 Modernization of the National Academy for Education Management (NAEM): The NAEM should be modernized to facilitate training and research in various educational matters. Regional NAEM offices could be established, and international training partnerships can be pursued.

14.10 Development of Technical Education: Technical education should be introduced from the eighth grade onward in schools. The number of technical institutions should be increased, and Polytechnic Institutes should be upgraded to international standards. Special measures should be taken to recruit high-quality teachers, and international assistance should be sought to improve the quality of technical education.

14.11 Madrasa Education Reform:

- a) Special high-level madrasas may be established in all divisions, with a women's government madrasa in each division.
- b) Primary and secondary level madrasas should ensure that primary school students have access to all the facilities provided in primary schools.
- c) Private madrasas should undergo special monitoring and investment to improve their quality, with policies to hire qualified principals and teachers.

14.12 Teacher Recruitment According to Student-Teacher Ratios: Due to the insufficient number of teachers relative to the student population, the recommendation is to increase the education sector's budget allocation to improve the teacher-student ratio. Special efforts should be made to fill vacant teaching positions.

14.13 Formation of College and Secondary School Managing Committees: It is recommended that government officials should manage private colleges and secondary schools to eliminate political interference in managing committees. This will ensure better governance and management of educational institutions.

14.14 Teacher Shortage in the Chittagong Hill Tracts: The region faces a severe shortage of teachers, especially due to its remote location. Special recruitment measures should be taken to address this issue, considering the local population's recommendations.

14.15 Establishment of Residential Schools in the Chittagong Hill Tracts: Due to the difficulty of commuting long distances to schools in remote hill areas, the government should consider setting up residential schools. Additionally, satellite-based internet and online schooling systems could be introduced.

These recommendations aim to improve the quality and accessibility of education in Bangladesh and address key challenges faced by the education sector.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN: SPECIAL RECOMMENDATIONS FOR THE REFORM OF PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION IN THE HILL DISTRICTS:

The following recommendations have been presented, addressing coordination among various authorities, development of the tourism and sports industries, risk allowances, education reforms, officer appointments, citizen participation in services, forest conservation, and improvements in healthcare:

- 15.1 Coordination Among Three Authorities:** There is a need for increased coordination among the district and upazila administrations, the Hill District Council, and the military in the three hill districts. Identifying and addressing issues through inter-agency discussions is necessary. Citizens should clearly understand which authority to approach for specific issues. The government may issue instructions for district administrators to initiate these discussions.
- 15.2 Political Interference-Free Public Administration:** Local experts in the hill districts have called for the establishment of a political interference-free public administration. Public administration in these areas should be prioritized for improvement. The government needs to assess whether district commissioners have equal authority across the three hill districts and ensure that their time is not spent unnecessarily on protocol tasks.
- 15.3 Development of the Tourism Industry:** The hill districts have significant potential for tourism, which should be prioritized through a comprehensive master plan. Immediate actions are recommended to address pollution in the Ranganamati Lake and to undertake special projects to make Sajek Valley a more attractive tourist destination.
- 15.4 Sports Development:** There is considerable potential for sports development among the indigenous communities in the hill districts. To harness this, the lack of coordination among various departments needs to be addressed. It is recommended to increase the number of staff at the district level to facilitate the organization of regular competitions and training sessions.
- 15.5 Risk Allowance for Government Employees:** Due to the challenging and risky working conditions in the hill districts, it is recommended to increase the risk allowance for government employees. The distinct nature of the conditions in these areas necessitates pre-posting orientation for officers. Furthermore, instead of punitive transfers, more capable and competent officers should be assigned to these challenging roles.
- 15.6 Filling Vacant Teaching Positions:** For the recruitment of teachers in the Ranganamati district, it is recommended that the National Teacher Registration Commission (NTRC), in collaboration with the district administration, take special measures. Additionally, efforts should be made to establish residential schools in the remote areas of the three hill districts.
- 15.7 Internet Connectivity via VSAT:** To improve internet access in the remote hill areas, it is proposed to provide VSAT-based internet connectivity, which can facilitate the implementation of online education.
- 15.8 Public Hearing Mechanism:** It is recommended that public hearings be conducted at the union level in the hill districts. Representatives of the target population should be included in the decision-making process before the implementation of any government program. There should also be a balance in the allocation of government funds to these districts.
- 15.9 Conservation of Forests and Biodiversity:** Special enforcement powers need to be increased for the conservation of 700,000 acres of forest and biodiversity in the hill districts.
- 15.10 Healthcare Center Improvement:** It is recommended to equip health centers in the hill districts with emergency medical equipment, including X-ray machines, to improve healthcare services.
- 15.11 Provision of Water Ambulances:** To improve accessibility for pregnant women and emergency patients, the introduction of water ambulances in the remote hill districts is recommended. There should also be an ICU bed facility for treating snakebite victims.
- 15.12 Addressing Police Force Issues:** It is recommended to review the transportation challenges, TA/DA, and other issues faced by the police force in the hill districts and to take special measures to address them. (Medium-term)

These recommendations aim to address the multifaceted challenges faced by the hill districts, ensuring effective public service delivery and overall development.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN: REFORMS FOR ENSURING A GENDER-FRIENDLY ENVIRONMENT IN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

The following discussions are made on various topics, including the appointment of female dignity officers in ministries, recruitment of women for transferable positions, prioritizing women in vacancies in education and healthcare sectors, recruitment of female wardens in prisons, female ASI appointments in police stations, increasing workforce in district women's departments, and providing housing for government officials and employees at the upazila level. The following recommendations have been presented:

- 16.1 Appointment of Female Dignity Officers in All Ministries:** It is recommended that each ministry/department appoint a female officer with specific responsibilities to create a gender-friendly work environment in their respective ministry/department

and its subordinate offices. This officer will inform the Ministry Secretary and the Women's Department in writing if there are any gender-discriminatory complaints.

16.2 Priority Appointment of Women in Non-Transferable Positions: It is recommended to give priority to the appointment of women in non-transferable positions. This would allow women to manage both their careers and family responsibilities with greater ease.

16.3 Priority Recruitment of Women in Education and Healthcare Sectors: It is proposed that women be given priority in recruitment for vacancies in the healthcare and education sectors, considering their unique qualities and relaxing general recruitment rules if necessary.

16.4 Appointment of Female Wardens in Prisons: Due to the increasing number of female prisoners, it is recommended that each prison appoint an adequate number of female wardens.

16.5 Appointment of Female ASIs in Police Stations: It is recommended to appoint one female Assistant Sub-Inspector (ASI) in every police station across the country, which will make it easier for women to file complaints and seek redress in a more comfortable environment.

16.6 Increasing Workforce in District Women's Department: It is recommended to increase the workforce in the District Women's Department and provide transportation at the district level to improve their operational effectiveness.

16.7 Housing for Government Officials/Employees at Upazila Level: There is a housing shortage for government officials/employees, especially women, at the upazila level. It is recommended that the government prioritize this issue and increase budget allocations to address the housing problem.

16.8 Sanitary Toilets at Highway Petrol Pumps: Although there are toilets at petrol pumps on highways, they are not always hygienic or clean, and in many places, separate facilities for women are absent. It is recommended that immediate action be taken to address these issues and ensure that the toilets are sanitary and well-maintained.

These recommendations aim to create a more inclusive, safe, and gender-sensitive working and living environment for women in various public administrative sectors.

In Chapter Seventeen, the strategies for implementing the reform proposals of the Public Administration Reform Commission are outlined.